

Ellwood to Wampum trail in the works

By Eric Poole Calkins Media | Posted: Sunday, October 30, 2011 9:45 pm

It's been a while -- around 50 years, since the United States' interstate system was completed -- that Ellwood City has been the hub of anything.

But that may change soon.

Lawrence County Planning Commission and officials from Ellwood City and Wampum are working on the creation of a walking/bicycling trail that would link the two municipalities and, while the trail would be only a shade more than 5 miles in length, it would close gaps for more than 5,000 miles worth of trails.

More importantly to Doniele Russell, greenways and environmental planner for Beaver and Lawrence counties, the planned trail would spark recreation-based economic development.

"It's not just the hiking; it's not just the biking," she said. "There is just so much economic and recreational opportunity there."

The trail would link Ellwood City and a planned rails-to-trails path along the former Harmony Short Line's northern spur in the east, with the North Country Trail, Beaver River Rails to Trails trail, and eventually with the Stavich Bike Trail.

The North Country Trail runs more than 4,500 miles from eastern New York state to central North Dakota. The path runs through Moraine State Park and Lawrence County, including Wampum. The Stavich Bike Trail runs from Union Township into eastern Ohio.

The Beaver River trails will eventually connect to Lake Erie and the Pittsburgh-to-Washington, D.C., trail. Rock Point's nature trail also will connect with the Ellwood-Wampum trail.

Plans for the Ellwood-Wampum trail have been discussed during two public meetings of the trail committee, which includes representatives from both municipalities. The trail will more or less follow Wampum Avenue to the Ellwood City borough line and Ellwood-Wampum Road into Wampum.

Russell said construction of the trail would call for widening the berm along Ellwood-Wampum Road in places.

Ellwood City Borough Manager Dom Viccari said planners would have liked to follow Connoquenessing Creek and the Beaver River more closely, but that would have required negotiation for right of ways on private properties. Another factor affecting the chosen trail path was the non-participation of Wayne Township, which sits between Ellwood City and Wampum.

Russell said Wayne officials balked at paying a \$750 fee to join the trail partnership.

Having Wayne Township on board would have been useful in obtaining funds for the projects, which Russell said was the next step. The trail committee is planning to apply for a grant through the Department of Conservation and Economic Development to get the project going.

Under the department's latest guidelines, grants are being evaluated based on the number of municipalities

participating and the project's ability to fill in trail gaps.

"If you gave me the money tomorrow, it would be done by next year," she said.

The project's first phase, which amounts to widening the berms where necessary and marking the path, will cost around \$50,000, Russell said.

Anyone interested in assisting with trail efforts can contact officials from either Ellwood City at (724) 758-7777 ext. 11 or Wampum at (724) 535-8241, or call Russell at (724) 656-2144. The trail group will probably hold another public meeting in early 2012.